Xinyi Fang

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Education

Saint Louis University — St. Louis, MO
Ph.D. in Computer Science — *Sep. 2026 – Present*
TRACE AI, advised by Prof. Jin Zhao

Brandeis University — Waltham, MA
Ph.D. Studies in Computer Science — *Aug. 2025 – Sep. 2026*
Transferred to Saint Louis University to work with Prof. Jin Zhao

Worcester Polytechnic Institute — Worcester, MA
Master of Science in Computer Science — *Aug. 2023 – May 2025*
MS Degree Thesis: *Enhancing Language Models for Classification on TAGs through Multi-Model Data Augmentation*
Adviser: Prof. Kyumin Lee
Contributed as a Reviewer for: SIGIR2024, SIGIR2025, WSDM2025

Guangzhou University — Guangzhou, China
Bachelor of Science in Data Science — *Aug. 2019 – May 2023*

Research Interests

Multimodal NLP; language understanding in social and cultural contexts; LLM and VLM evaluation; AI for social good.

Experience

Research Assistant — Sep. 2026 – Present
TRACE AI at Saint Louis University — *St. Louis, MO*
- Conducting research in NLP and multimodal understanding, examining how language and vision-language models interpret context, generate content, and capture social and cultural meaning in news and social media.
- Formulating research questions, designing empirical studies, and interpreting experimental findings, synthesizing quantitative results and qualitative observations into research conclusions and contributing to manuscript preparation.
- Training annotators and developing annotation guidelines, translating research concepts into practical examples and decision criteria, and clarifying ambiguous cases to support consistent judgments across text and image annotation tasks.

Teaching Assistant — Aug. 2025 – Sep. 2026
Brandeis University — *Waltham, MA*
- COSI104a - S26: Introduction to Machine Learning
- COSI114a - F25: Fundamentals of Natural Language Processing I

Teaching Assistant — Aug. 2024 – May 2025
Worcester Polytechnic Institute — *Worcester, MA*
- CS573 - S25: Data Visualization
- CS5084 - F24: Introduction to Algorithms: Design and Analysis

Publications

Xinyi Fang, Jin Zhao. "How Hard is it to Identify AI-Generated Meme Ideas?" *AACL-IJCNLP 2026 SRW (to appear).*

Xinyi Fang, Kyumin Lee, Yichuan Li. " LLM Profiling and Fine-Tuning with Limited Neighbor Information for Node Classification on Text-Attributed Graphs. " *5th Workshop on KG and BigData, IEEE Big Data (KGBigdata 2025).*

Projects

Framing in Multimodal Event-Graph | *PyTorch, vLLM, Transformers, PEFT, PyTorch Geometric* — Aug. 2026 – Present
- Conducted research on multimodal news understanding and framing, linking images with event information across multiple articles to support systematic analysis of how news outlets select and visually represent different aspects of a shared event.
- Built LLM-assisted pipelines for data processing, event extraction, and structured representation, integrating source verification, automated consistency checks, and human annotation workflows to support multimodal dataset construction.
- Implemented and evaluated neural baselines and vision–language models, exploring parameter-efficient fine-tuning and structured inference through controlled experiments to assess multimodal sensitivity to contextual information.

Detecting AI-Generated Meme Ideas | *vLLM, PyTorch, Transformers, Unsloth, scikit-learn* — Dec. 2025 – Jul. 2026
- Developed a dataset and evaluation pipeline using 2,735 Reddit memes, extracting visual template descriptions and structured text with a vision-language model and generating template-matched meme ideas with three open-weight LLMs.
- Benchmarked four LLMs across nine generator–detector pairs under zero-shot, few-shot, and chain-of-thought prompting, conducting five seeded runs per setting to evaluate AI-generated meme idea detection.
- Conducted human evaluation and lexical analysis using spaCy and Scattertext; fine-tuned Gemma 4 with LoRA on 1,000 examples, achieving 93.08% accuracy and 92.92% F1 on a 3,970-sample held-out test set.